

Lab 6 - Thread Text Across Frames and Resolve Overset Copy

Topic 02: Basic InDesign Drawing Techniques | LO2 | TGS-2021007827

The Situation

The Bellow Flower feature article, HP_Brochure_BellowFlower.docx, runs to about 900 words and must flow across four panels of the Harmony Petals brochure. Yesterday the file went to Sun Ray Printers with a red overset marker nobody noticed; the proof came back with the last paragraph of the founder's story simply missing, and the client refused to approve it. Priya has asked you to re-do the flow properly and to demonstrate, in front of her, that no copy is hidden. She also wants the article to autoflow so that if the copywriter adds two more paragraphs on Friday, the brochure extends itself rather than silently truncating.

At a Glance

Learning outcome	LO2
Objective	Refine a text layout by threading a story across multiple frames and pages, and diagnose and resolve overset text so no client copy is lost at output (TSC A2, A4).
You will produce	HP_Brochure_2.indd with the Bellow Flower story threaded across four frames, zero overset text, visible thread indicators, and a Preflight panel reporting no errors.
Tools and panels	Adobe InDesign In/out ports Autoflow (Shift-click) Semi-autoflow (Alt/Opt-click) View > Extras > Show Text Threads Edit > Edit in Story Editor Preflight panel
Starter InDesign file	HP_Brochure_2.indd
Final filename	Lab-06-Completed.indd

What You Will Do

Import a long story and thread it manually between frames using the in and out ports, then repeat the flow using semi-autoflow and autoflow with modifier keys. You learn to spot the red plus sign of overset text, use Story Editor and Preflight to prove nothing is lost, and unthread a frame without deleting its content.

Phase 1 - Prepare and Baseline

1. Read this guide completely, then duplicate HP_Brochure_2.indd as Lab-06-Working.indd.
2. Create an Evidence/ folder beside the working file.
3. Open the working copy and capture the starting Pages, Links or Preflight panel most relevant to the task.
4. Keep every linked asset inside this lab folder: never relink to Downloads, Desktop or a network path.

Starter role: Brochure starter containing frames that must be threaded and cleared of overset text.

Phase 2 - Build

Step-by-Step Procedure

1. Open HP_Brochure_2.indd and turn on View > Extras > Show Text Threads so the links between frames are visible when frames are selected.

View > Extras > Show Text Threads

2. With nothing selected, choose File > Place and select HP_Brochure_BellowFlower.docx; the cursor becomes a loaded text icon.

File > Place | HP_Brochure_BellowFlower.docx

3. Click once inside the first panel guide area to place the story into a single frame; note the red plus sign in the out port at the lower right.

4. Switch to the Selection tool (V), click the red out port once - the cursor reloads - then click or drag in the second panel to thread the continuation.

V, then click the out port

5. Repeat for the third panel to confirm you can control the flow frame by frame.

6. Undo back to the loaded cursor, then hold Alt (Windows) or Option (macOS) and click to use semi-autoflow, which keeps the cursor loaded after each placement.

Alt/Opt-click = semi-autoflow

7. Undo again and hold Shift while clicking to autoflow the whole story, letting InDesign add frames and pages until the copy is exhausted.

Shift-click = autoflow

8. Select a middle frame and choose Edit > Edit in Story Editor; scroll to the end and confirm no text sits below the overset depth line.

Edit > Edit in Story Editor | Ctrl/Cmd+Y

9. Open Window > Output > Preflight, enable it, and confirm the [Basic] profile reports 0 errors with no overset text entry.

Window > Output > Preflight

10. Select the final frame and click its in port, then click the out port of the preceding frame to break the thread; observe that the text re-flows back rather than being deleted.

Click in port to unthread

11. Re-thread the final frame, then use Layout > Pages and the Pages panel to verify no unintended pages were added by autoflow. Save the file.

File > Save

Verify Your Work

- ☐ Done when: Preflight reports 0 errors, Story Editor shows no copy below the overset line, and selecting any frame displays continuous thread arrows through all four panels.

Evidence and Submission

- [] Updated HP_Brochure_2.indd
- [] Visible text-thread screenshot
- [] No-overset Preflight screenshot
- [] Final native file saved as Lab-06-Completed.indd
- [] All linked assets remain inside this lab folder or its subfolders
- [] No overset text, missing fonts or missing links remain unless the task explicitly asks you to diagnose them

Recovery Path

1. If the working file is damaged, close it without saving and duplicate HP_Brochure_2.indd again.
2. If links are missing, use the Links panel Relink command and select the matching file inside this lab folder.
3. If fonts are missing, activate Adobe Fonts or substitute an approved font, then check for reflow and overset text.
4. Re-run the verification gate and recapture evidence after recovery.

If It Doesn't Work

If clicking the out port creates a brand-new empty frame instead of continuing the story, you clicked with the Type tool rather than the Selection tool - press V first. If autoflow silently added six unwanted pages, you Shift-clicked with Smart Text Reflow enabled; undo, reduce the type size or enlarge the frames, then re-flow.

Stretch Challenge

Insert enough copy to force a new page, then compare manual threading with Smart Text Reflow and record the safer choice for this brochure.

Discussion Questions

1. A red plus sign appears in the out port of a text frame. Explain precisely what it means and name three different ways to resolve it.
2. Compare manual flow, semi-autoflow and autoflow. Which modifier key triggers each, and in what production situation would you deliberately choose the slowest of the three?
3. You delete a threaded frame in the middle of a story. What happens to the text it contained, and why?
4. Why is Story Editor a more reliable way to find overset copy than scrolling the layout looking for red markers?
5. Priya's overset paragraph was invisible on screen but caused a rejected proof. What preflight or handover check should be standard before any file leaves the studio?

Reference Artwork

[!Lab 6](#)

Reference Basis

ACP guide domain 4: text flow, in/out ports, threading, overset text and multi-frame stories.

Current Adobe Help:

<https://helpx.adobe.com/indesign/desktop/add-and-manage-text/add-and-import-text/thread-text-frames.html>

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